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What They're Saying: California Jewish Leaders Support the University of California System

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BERKELEY, California, Aug. 14 -- The University of California issued the following news release:

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What they're saying: California Jewish Leaders support the University of California system

Today, California Jewish leaders expressed support for UCLA and the UC system, following reports that the federal government is seeking a $1.172 billion settlement from UCLA after freezing $584 million in groundbreaking federal research funding on UC campuses.

Here is what they are saying:

"Addressing the serious challenge of antisemitism requires thoughtful engagement, not reckless political gamesmanship that harms our national interests and jeopardizes lifesaving medical research," said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino), co-chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus. "I have seen firsthand the improvements that UCLA has made under Chancellor Frenk's leadership, and I appreciate his thoughtful engagement with Jewish students, faculty, and community leaders. There is still important work to be done, but stripping away critical funding will only harm the students, researchers, and communities that UCLA serves every day."

"While there have been serious antisemitism issues at UCLA, we're addressing the issue here in California and have made progress. As co-chair of the Legislative Jewish Caucus, I have seen how seriously Chancellor Frenk and the UC leadership take this issue, and the concrete action they are taking to improve conditions for Jewish students, teachers and alumni," said state Senator Scott Weiner, co-chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus. "The Trump Administration claims to care about antisemitism at UCLA, but its actions do nothing but make it harder for UC leadership to implement policies and initiatives to make Jewish students safer. The Administration's actions endanger Jews by using the Jewish community as a shield for their anti-democratic and unpopular attempts to control every aspect of American life. Cutting federal grants that fund lifesaving cancer research, scientific breakthroughs and educational opportunities hurts Americans of all backgrounds, and announcing these draconian measures in the name of Jewish students only makes the fight against antisemitism harder."

"This is yet another iteration of the Administration harming the engines of American power, innovation, and, indeed, greatness," said California state Senator and former chair of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus Ben Allen. "Demanding $1 billion from a publicly funded, leading research institution is a misuse of tax dollars that will hurt the University's mission of serving students and the public. UCLA, and the larger UC system, have taken meaningful steps to make it clear that combating antisemitism and protecting Jewish students, faculty, and community members on campus is a top priority. They have been committed to increasing security, strengthening policies against hate, and engaging directly with Jewish voices to better inform their approach. If the Administration's mission is truly to protect the Jewish community, they would be supporting that work -- not hamstringing it with these outlandish demands that would only take away needed resources and services for students and faculty."

"Like many universities nationwide, UCLA has faced serious antisemitic incidents. In partnership with JPAC and its member organizations, California's leadership, the UC system, and UCLA have taken steps to counter antisemitism and ensure the safety and inclusion of Jewish students and faculty. UCLA's new Chancellor Julio Frenk is an active partner and champion in these efforts, making it clear through actions and policies that antisemitism has no place

on campus," said the Jewish Public Affairs Committee of California. "Substantial work remains to effectively fight antisemitism on campus. However, cutting vital federal research funding or imposing a billion-dollar penalty would instead harm students, disrupt life-saving research, threaten economic growth, and undermine one of the nation's most respected public university systems. It will drive a wedge between the Jewish community and other vulnerable groups that are harmed. And as a public institution, such a settlement would ironically divert public funds from other initiatives, including those that combat antisemitism and hate. This approach leaves everyone less safe. JPAC urges the Administration to reconsider imposing financial penalties, and instead seek constructive, collaborative, and strategic avenues to address the alarming rise in antisemitism on college campuses."

"UCLA has had an antisemitism problem and has not always dealt with this problem well," said Congressman Brad Sherman. "Their current leadership has committed to address this and I look forward to working with them to do so. But Trump's effort to impose a $1 billion fine is simply outrageous and harms the effort to deal with antisemitism at UCLA."

"Neither the Trump Administration's billion-dollar shakedown, nor withholding more than 500 million dollars in vital scientific research funding, will do anything to fight antisemitism at UCLA," said Zev Yaroslavsky, former Los Angeles County Supervisor. "I've seen firsthand how Chancellor Julio Frenk and his team have addressed antisemitism. They have taken tangible and meaningful steps to ensure that UCLA's Jewish students and faculty are safe and supported on campus. If the Trump Administration has additional ideas, let them propose them, but bankrupting the University is not a constructive proposal."

"The explosion of anti-Jewish hate in our cities and our campuses is unacceptable, poses a threat to the very fabric of our democratic society and demands concrete action from our leaders in government, on campuses, and across communities. The Administration's demand that UCLA pay $1 billion to restore hundreds of millions of already-revoked funding, however, would deal a devastating blow to one of our nation's most vital institutions of research and education, while accomplishing nothing in the fight against antisemitism. UCLA has taken concrete and far-reaching steps to combat antisemitism under the leadership of Chancellor Julio Frenk, who has been an outspoken advocate for Jewish students and faculty since the day he arrived on campus. While there is more work to be done, I have seen firsthand how UCLA is becoming a model for how to address this issue head on. I share the Administration's concern about rampant antisemitism that continues to spread on American campuses, and I know Chancellor Frenk does too," said Sharon Nazarian, President of the Y&S Nazarian Family Foundation.

"The President's decision to withdraw funding from UCLA threatens vital academic, life-saving research and community services which UCLA provides to Los Angeles, the state, and the entire country. Playing vindictive politics with our institutions of higher learning and the academics and research they provide is reckless and harmful. Particularly offensive is the Administration's bogus explanation that the cuts are related to campus antisemitism; there is no connection whatsoever between antisemitism and the vital services being targeted. While, of course, addressing campus antisemitism is critically important, using it as a justification for this clearly political act of vengeance is misguided, harmful, and nonsensical, and ultimately actually militates against combating antisemitism. Our entire community should be outraged by this action," said Janice Kamenir-Reznik, co-founder of Jewish World Watch and Jews United for Democracy & Justice.

"I've spoken with students who have felt unsafe or isolated, and I've seen the changes UCLA has made firsthand to resolve their concerns," said Howard Welinsky, board member for UCLA Hillel and former chair of Jewish Public Affairs Council of California. "Jewish students want to feel seen, heard, and protected, and UCLA is moving in the right direction. Pulling federal support will put UCLA 10 steps behind the effort to curb antisemitism."

"UCLA has not only acknowledged the rise in antisemitism, but it has also made significant improvements, from bolstering campus policy to building partnerships with Jewish community-rooted organizations," said former Congressman Mel Levine. "These cuts will undermine vital research and will do nothing to right antisemitism. Cutting funding now only derails the work UCLA is doing and sends the wrong message to campuses across the country who are working in good faith to become more welcoming to Jewish students."

"The Trump Administration's actions against one this country's greatest public universities will do nothing but harm

the countless Americans who rely on the vital research and innovation that happens at UCLA every day," said Darrell Steinberg, former Sacramento mayor, former California Senate President pro Tempore and former chairman of the Sacramento Jewish Community Council. "The Administration claims this is in response to the rise in antisemitism on campus but cutting medical and scientific research does nothing to make Jewish students safer. Of all the schools to target, the Administration chose UCLA, whose leaders have taken concrete action and treated the fight against antisemitism with the gravity it warrants. These actions undermine UC's good-faith efforts to engage the Jewish community and create an environment where Jewish students and faculty can thrive."

"UCLA was my launch pad and the school's innovations have improved the lives of countless Angelenos and people around the globe," said Rachel Sumekh, founding board member, Jewish Partnership for Los Angeles. "Antisemitism on campus is a serious problem, but threatening UCLA's funding does nothing to solve it. It only hurts students, researchers, and the communities they serve."

"Settlement demands that will gut UCLA's vital medical and other research do nothing to protect Jewish students -- in fact, they undermine the education and future of Jewish, and all, students. Instead of exploiting our community's legitimate concerns about antisemitism to undercut our academic institutions and our democratic norms, the Administration should be investing in the constructive policies and programs that are proven to strengthen campus accountability, effectively counter antisemitism and hate, and advance student safety," said Amy Spitalnick, CEO of the Jewish Council for Public Affairs.

"We support the recent actions being taken by the UCLA administration to directly address campus antisemitism. Institutions of learning and research must not be targets of ideological suppression or financial intimidation. JUDJ stands in solidarity with the University of California leadership and the Governor of California who have correctly objected to terms that dishonor the values of public higher education and its vital role in serving students, innovation, and the public good," said Jews United for Democracy & Justice (JUDJ).

"In the months following October 7, college campuses across the country saw an alarming rise in antisemitism," said Leo Spiegel, past chair of Trustees, UC San Diego and former chair, Jewish Community Foundation of San Diego. "The University of California has made good on its promise to Jewish students and faculty to make combating antisemitism a top institutional priority. It has strengthened policies, enhanced community safety, and engaged with Jewish communities across the state. Now, that progress is being undermined by federal actions that stoke division. The University of California isn't just a state institution; it's a global leader in research, innovation, education, and health care. The University's breakthroughs benefit all Americans. This isn't just about California. It's about America's future. I stand with the UC community in its mission to improve lives everywhere."

"UC has sent a clear message that there is no place and no excuse on any campus for antisemitism or the threat of violence against Jewish students; that all forms of antisemitism are antithetical to the University's values and will not be tolerated," said Hannah-Beth Jackson, former California state Senator and chair of the California State Senate Committee on the Judiciary and a founding member of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus.

"This action dramatically undermines the ability of the University to conduct ground-breaking medical, scientific and other research for the good of California, the U.S. and the world and has no impact on the efforts of the University to combat antisemitism," said Jim Koshland, founding member of Friends of the University and treasurer of New Israel Fund. "In fact, tying this action to antisemitism may hurt the ability of the University to combat antisemitism."

Read more about UC's work combating antisemitism (https://www.universityofcalifornia.edu/press-room/combating-antisemitism).

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Original text here: https://www.universityofcalifornia.edu/press-room/what-theyre-saying-california-jewish-leaders-support-university-california-system

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